2. Setting Up a Zoho Creator Account and Exploring the Platform Architecture and Interface

Aim

To sign in to Zoho Creator and explore its platform architecture, features and user interface for developing low-code applications.

Theory

Zoho Creator is a cloud-based low-code platform on which business applications are built by configuring forms, reports, pages and workflows, with the Deluge language available for custom logic. Its main building blocks are:

- **Application:** the container that holds every form, report, page, workflow and setting.
- **Forms:** collect and store data in fields of different types.
- **Reports:** present the stored data as lists, spreadsheets, charts and other views.
- **Pages:** custom screens such as dashboards made from several components.
- **Workflows:** event-based automation (form, schedule, approval, Blueprint and others).
- **Deluge:** the scripting language used for validations, fetches, emails and updates.
- **Users and permissions:** profiles and roles that decide who can see and change what.

Procedure

1. Open a browser, go to Zoho Creator and sign in with the Zoho account. The home page lists the applications of the account. The left menu is grouped as Develop (Applications, Microservices), Deploy (Environments, Mobile, Portal) and Manage (Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing).

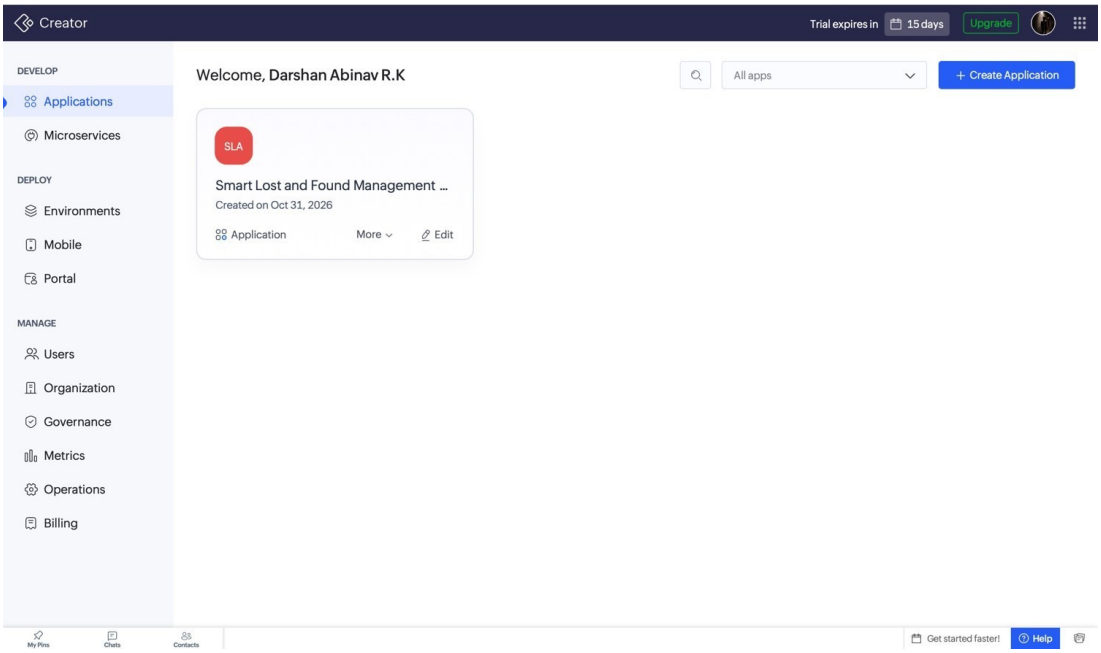


Fig. 2.1: Zoho Creator home page showing the application Smart Lost and Found Management System

2. Create a new application from the Create Application button. The application Smart Lost and Found Management System was created (trial edition) and appears as a card with the options Application, More and Edit.
3. Open the application with Edit to reach the builder. The Design view lists the forms, reports, workflows and pages of the application.
4. Open the Application (live) mode to see how users see it: the menu on the left and a form or report in the main area.

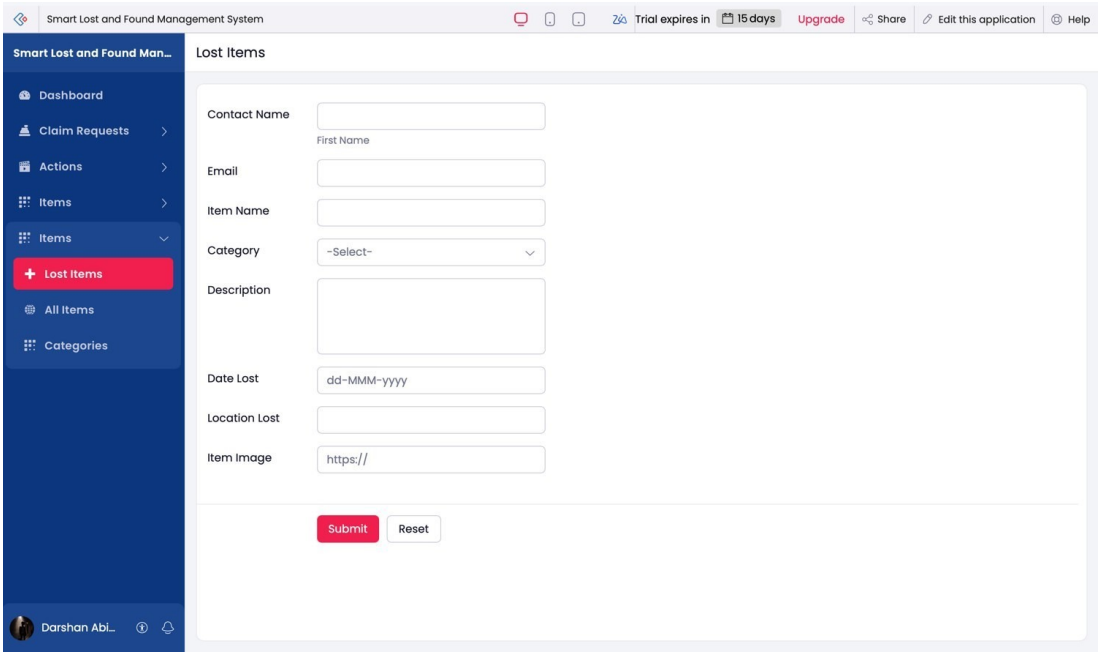


Fig. 2.2: Lost Items form of the application in live mode

5. Open the Workflow tab to see the workflows attached to each form, and the Settings tab for users and other options.

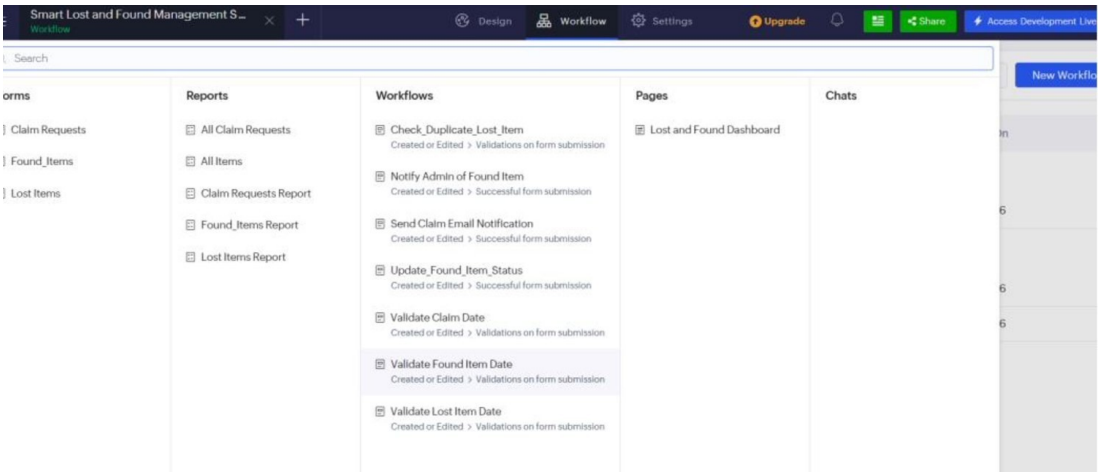


Fig. 2.3: Workflow view listing forms, reports, workflows and the page of the application

Result

A Zoho Creator account was used to create and open the application Smart Lost and Found Management System, and the platform architecture and interface (home page, Design, Workflow and live views) were explored.